the far more lucrative trade in trafficking Rohingyas into camps and then selling them on to other fishing captains.[89] Thailand's complicity with this business is so deep that it is in danger of being categorised, along with North Korea, as the world's worst abusers in the US State Department's Human Trafficking Index.[90] Recent evidence has implicated Thai officials directly in the trade, not just in turning a blind eye but in collecting Rohingyas from the traffickers when they arrive in Thailand and transporting them to jungle camps where they are held for ransom or sold to fishing boats.[91]

Of course, the problem is not just with Thailand. Western companies that source cheap prawns from the region, especially from Thailand, are complicit.[92] And though we may choose not to be aware of it, that part of our food supply chain is based on human misery in Myanmar too. In that sense at least, we are also complicit in this situation.

A lifetime of slavery in the Thai fishing industry, though, is not the only grim prospect that awaits Rohingya refugees who pay people-traffickers to escape Myanmar. Those who make it to land are no safer. If not sold into slavery, many are held in camps on the Thailand–Malaysia border, and recently mass graves have been uncovered of those who have died in captivity.[93] Individuals are held until their families can afford to pay a ransom.[94] Those who cannot pay are either killed or sold as slaves. Even if they escape this fate, many then work illegally with no protection.[95] Women and children are especially vulnerable to sexual exploitation[96] and there are regular reports of women starving themselves so their children can eat. There are also consistent reports of women being forced into prostitution or marriage as part of the price of being released by the smugglers,[97] and for some families selling a female member into marriage is a means to pay for their collective escape from Myanmar.

A Rohingya who survived has described their own ordeal:

> I spent 14 days on this ship. Three days after we were transferred, three smugglers arrived from Malaysia and boarded our ship. They carried mobile phones. They first asked who had phone numbers and, one by one, we started calling our relatives. Those [who did not provide] phone numbers were beaten … The smugglers ordered passengers to beat them with engine chains wrapped in plastic and plastic pipes with something heavy inside. Even those with phone numbers were beaten. The abuses continued until families sent money, after which survivors were taken to shore by small fishing boats. … Before I left, I witnessed three men who had become paralysed and one dead body was thrown overboard.[98]